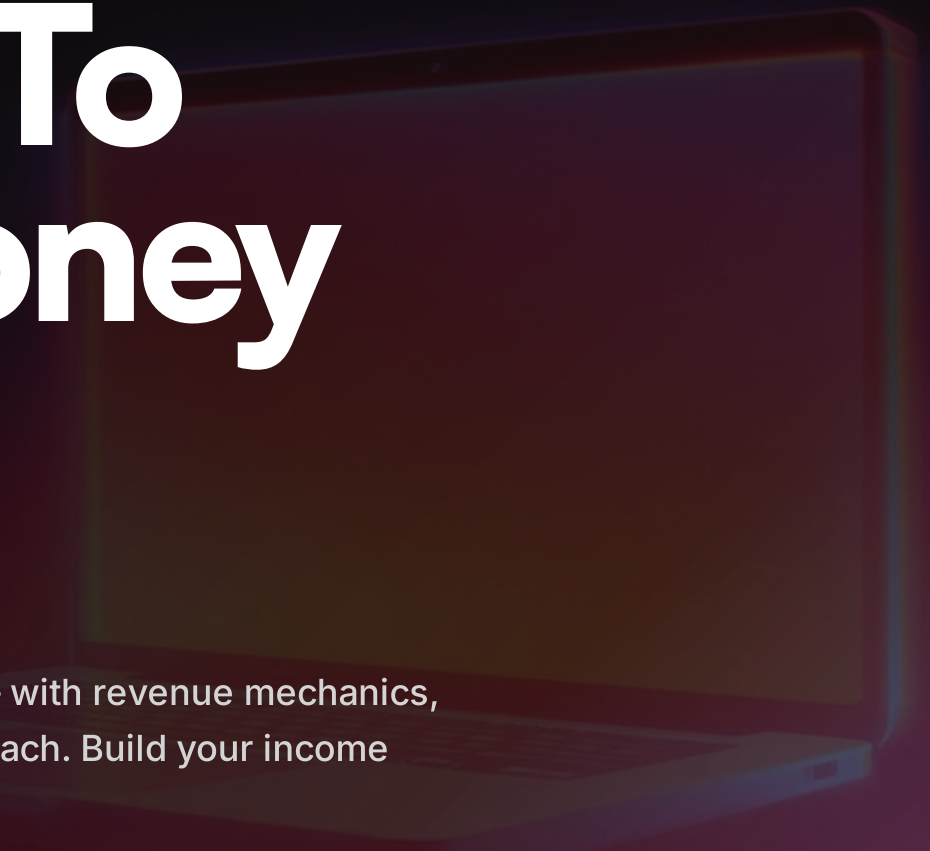
ONLINE INCOME · OPERATOR PLAYBOOK

91 Ways To Make Money Online.



Every monetization play available in 2026 — with revenue mechanics, capital requirements, and time-to-cash for each. Build your income stack.

91
INCOME PLAYS

6
CATEGORIES

FOREWORD

The internet has compressed the path from idea to income to a single weekend. Most people don't realize the gate is open.

— The Editors, Z.AI Strategy Press

ABOUT THIS PLAYBOOK

This playbook catalogs every realistic way to make money online in 2026 — 91 plays across 6 categories. For each, you'll find the model, capital requirements, time-to-first-dollar, and revenue ceiling.

This is not a "get rich quick" book. Every play in here requires real work. The point is to show you the menu — so you can pick the plays that fit your skills, capital, and timeline.

91 PLAYS | 6 CATEGORIES | OPERATOR-GRADE

READING GUIDE

Three ways to use this playbook.

Pick the play mode that matches your current situation.

01

The Browser

Skim all 91 plays to expand your sense of what's possible. Most people underestimate the menu. Read cover to cover for the full map.

TIME REQUIRED

≈30 min skim

02

The Picker

Jump to the Strategy section to filter plays by capital, time, and skill. Then read deep on the 3–5 that fit you.

TIME REQUIRED

≈45 min deep

03

The Builder

Use the 30/90/365-day roadmap at the end to execute. Pick 1 play for cash, 1 play for equity. Run them in parallel.

TIME REQUIRED

90-day sprint

CONTENTS

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All 91 plays · 6 categories · Updated Q1 2026

LANDSCAPE

The internet is the largest economy ever built.

$7.8T

GLOBAL DIGITAL ECONOMY SIZE (2025, IMF)

The internet economy is bigger than every country except the US and China. Your share is waiting — but only if you know where to look.

1.57B

PEOPLE EARNING ONLINE INCOME GLOBALLY

73%

OF ONLINE EARNERS STARTED POST-2020

$1,200

MEDIAN MONTHLY ONLINE INCOME (TOP QUARTILE)

The new math:

1,000 true fans × $100/yr = $100K/yr. The internet made "small audience, premium pricing" viable. This entire playbook assumes that model.

01 / 06

Quick Wins. Ways 1—15.

Low capital, fast cash. Plays you can start this week with $0–$500 and earn your first dollar in 7–30 days.

IN THIS SECTION

- Freelance writing
- Virtual assistant
- Online tutoring
- Transcription
- Translation
- Graphic design
- Voice-over
- Video editing
- Social media mgmt
- Data entry
- Website testing
- Surveys & focus groups

WAY 01 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Freelance Writing

THE PLAY

Freelance writing is the lowest-friction online income. Brands need blog posts, emails, landing pages, and whitepapers — and AI has made production 5× faster without killing rates for quality writers. Start on Upwork and Contently. Pitch SaaS, fintech, and B2B companies — they pay $200–800/article. With Claude as your drafting partner, you can ship 3–5 articles/day. The play: niche down (e.g., 'B2B SaaS case study writer'), build 3 samples, pitch 50 companies/week. Realistic income: $3K–8K/mo within 90 days.

MODEL	**Per-project or per-word**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$8K/mo**

STACK

Upwork, Contently, LinkedIn

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 02 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Virtual Assistant (VA)

THE PLAY

VAs handle email, calendar, travel, research, and admin for busy founders. AI has expanded what a VA can do — you can now manage CRMs, draft content, and run automations. Best for organized, detail-oriented operators. Start on Belay or Time Etc. Charge $25–75/hr depending on niche. The play: specialize in 'AI-augmented VA' services (n8n workflows, AI scheduling, CRM automation) — 2× the rate of generalist VAs.

MODEL	**Hourly or monthly retainer**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$6K/mo**

STACK

Belay, Time Etc, Upwork

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 03 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Online Tutoring

THE PLAY

Online tutoring pays $25–100/hr depending on subject. Test prep (SAT, MCAT, GRE) and STEM (math, physics, CS) pay highest. Outschool lets you teach group classes to kids at $15–40/seat × 8 seats. The play: get 1–2 testimonials, then move off-platform and charge direct at 2× the rate. AI tools (Khan Academy's Khanmigo) augment — don't replace — human tutors.

MODEL	**Hourly**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$5K/mo**

STACK

Wyzant, Preply, Outschool

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 04 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Language Teaching

THE PLAY

Native English speakers can earn $15–30/hr on iTalki and Preply teaching conversation. Specialized tutors (business English, accent reduction, IELTS prep) earn $40–80/hr. The play: niche down by learner type — 'English for software engineers' or 'English for medical professionals.' Lower competition, higher rates.

MODEL	**Hourly**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$4K/mo**

STACK

iTalki, Preply, Cambly

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 05 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Transcription

THE PLAY

Audio-to-text transcription pays $0.30–1.50/audio minute. AI (Otter, Whisper) does 80% of the work now — your job is editing. Best for fast typists with good ears. Medical and legal transcription pay 3× general rates. The play: use Whisper for first draft, charge premium for accuracy. Don't compete on price with non-AI transcribers — compete on speed.

MODEL	**Per audio minute**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**3 days**
CEILING	**$3K/mo**

STACK

Rev, TranscribeMe, Otter

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 06 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Translation

THE PLAY

Bilingual speakers can earn $0.05–0.30/word translating. Specialized (legal, medical, technical) pays $0.20–0.50/word. AI (DeepL, Claude) handles drafts — you edit. The play: pair English + a high-demand language (Mandarin, Arabic, German, Japanese). Specialize in technical or marketing translation — 3× general rates.

MODEL	**Per word**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$6K/mo**

STACK

ProZ, Gengo, TranslatorsCafe

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 07 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Graphic Design

THE PLAY

Logo, brand, and social media design pays $200–2K/project. AI tools (Midjourney for inspiration, Figma AI for layout) compress design time 5×. The play: niche down — 'logo design for SaaS startups' or 'presentation design for VC pitches.' Build 10 portfolio pieces. Cold-pitch 100 founders/week. Realistic: $5K/mo in 90 days.

MODEL	**Per-project**
CAPITAL	**$20**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$10K/mo**

STACK

Figma, 99designs, Upwork

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 08 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Voice-Over

THE PLAY

Voice-over pays $200–500/finished minute for commercials, audiobooks, and e-learning. ACX (Audible) pays $50–400/finished hour + royalties. You need a quiet room, decent mic ($200), and free DAW (Audacity). The play: niche voice (corporate, character, kids' content). Build a 3-min demo reel. List on Voices.com + ACX + Fiverr.

MODEL	**Per word or per project**
CAPITAL	**$200**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$8K/mo**

STACK

Voices.com, ACX, ElevenLabs

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 09 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Video Editing

THE PLAY

YouTube editors charge $300–2K/video. Retainers: $2K–8K/mo per creator. AI tools (Descript, Premiere AI, CapCut) cut editing time 60%. The play: niche by content type — 'short-form for podcasters' or 'long-form for tech YouTubers.' Find 10 creators you love, edit 1 of their videos free as a sample, pitch retainer. Realistic: $5K/mo in 60 days.

MODEL	**Per video or retainer**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$12K/mo**

STACK

Premiere, DaVinci, CapCut

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 10 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Thumbnail Design

THE PLAY

YouTube thumbnails pay $30–200 each. Top creators need 4–8/wk. With Photoshop + Midjourney, you can produce 10/day. The play: study MrBeast, Ali Abdaal, Codie Sanchez thumbnails — analyze patterns. Build a 20-thumbnail portfolio. DM 50 mid-size YouTubers (50K–500K subs) offering first thumbnail free.

MODEL	**Per thumbnail**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$5K/mo**

STACK

Photoshop, Canva, Midjourney

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 11 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Social Media Management

THE PLAY

Brands pay $500–3K/mo per platform for social media management. With Claude + Buffer, one operator can manage 8–10 accounts. The play: specialize in 1 platform (LinkedIn for B2B, TikTok for e-commerce). Show 30 days of free posts as proof. Pitch 50 SMBs/month. Land 3 clients = $3–9K MRR.

MODEL	**Monthly retainer**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$10K/mo**

STACK

Buffer, Later, Claude

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 12 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Community Moderation

THE PLAY

Discord servers, Reddit communities, and paid communities need moderators. Pay: $15–40/hr or $500–2K/mo retainer per community. Best for people who are already active in a niche. The play: join 5 communities in your niche, become a top contributor, then offer paid moderation services to the admins.

MODEL	**Hourly or monthly**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**7 days**
CEILING	**$4K/mo**

STACK

Discord, Reddit, Circle

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 13 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Data Entry

THE PLAY

Data entry pays $10–20/hr on Clickworker and MTurk. Low skill, low ceiling, but zero barrier. AI has eaten most of the high-value data entry — what's left is grunt work. The play: use it as a stopgap while you build a higher-leverage skill (writing, design, video). Don't make it your main income for more than 60 days.

MODEL	**Per task or hourly**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**3 days**
CEILING	**$2K/mo**

STACK

Clickworker, Amazon MTurk

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 14 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Website & App Testing

THE PLAY

UserTesting pays $10–60 per 15–60 min test. Record your screen + voice as you use a website or app. Tests are first-come-first-served. The play: keep the UserTesting tab open all day, take every test that pops. Realistic: $300–1,500/mo part-time. Best as side income, not main income.

MODEL	**Per test**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**3 days**
CEILING	**$1.5K/mo**

STACK

UserTesting, Userlytics

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 15 / 091

QUICK WINS · SECTION 01

Focus Groups & Market Research

THE PLAY

Focus groups pay $50–400/hr for your opinion. Respondent and User Interviews are the top platforms. Higher pay for B2B professionals (software engineers, marketers, doctors). The play: sign up for 5 platforms, fill out profile completely, take every qualifying survey. Realistic: $500–2K/mo part-time.

MODEL	Per session
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	7 days
CEILING	$2K/mo

STACK

Respondent, User Interviews

OPERATOR GRADE

02 / 06

Content Creation. Ways 16—35.

Build audience, monetize attention. Higher ceiling, longer ramp. 6–12 months to first dollar, $50K+/mo ceiling.

IN THIS SECTION

- YouTube
- Shorts / TikTok
- Instagram Reels
- Podcasting
- Audiobook narration
- Blogging (SEO)
- Paid newsletter
- E-books / KDP
- Online courses
- Membership sites
- Stock photography
- Notion templates

WAY 16 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

YouTube Channel

THE PLAY

YouTube is the highest-ceiling content play. Ad revenue: $3–15 per 1,000 views. Sponsorships: $20–50 per 1,000 views. At 100K monthly views: $5K–15K/mo. At 1M views: $50K–150K/mo. The play: pick a niche with high CPM (finance, tech, business). Publish 2×/week for 24 months. The first 6 months = no money. Months 6–18 = traction. Months 18–36 = compounding.

MODEL	**Ad revenue + sponsorships + products**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$100K+/mo**

STACK

Camera, DaVinci, TubeBuddy

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 17 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

YouTube Shorts / TikTok

THE PLAY

Short-form video pays via creator funds ($0.50–2 per 1K views) + sponsorships ($200–2K per post at 100K followers). The play: post 1–3× DAILY. Pick a format (talking head, B-roll, listicle). Viral hits drive 80% of growth. Realistic: 100K followers in 6 months → $3K–10K/mo. Top creators: $30K+/mo.

MODEL	**Creator Fund + sponsorships**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**3–6 mo**
CEILING	**$30K/mo**

STACK

CapCut, TikTok, Phone

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 18 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Instagram Reels + Brand Deals

THE PLAY

Instagram pays via brand sponsorships ($100–5K per post at 10K–100K followers). Affiliate links add 10–30%. The play: niche aesthetic — fashion, fitness, food, travel. Post Reels daily. Reach out to 10 brands/week in your niche with a media kit. Realistic: 50K followers in 9 months → $5K–15K/mo.

MODEL	**Sponsorships + affiliate**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**3–6 mo**
CEILING	**$25K/mo**

STACK

Instagram, CapCut

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 19 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Podcasting

THE PLAY

Podcast sponsorships pay $18–50 per 1K downloads (CPM). At 10K downloads/episode × 4 episodes/mo = $720–2K/mo. At 50K downloads/episode = $3.6K–10K/mo. The play: niche interview podcast. Publish weekly. Cross-post clips to YouTube Shorts + TikTok. Realistic: 10K downloads/episode in 12 months.

MODEL	**Sponsorships + Patreon + ads**
CAPITAL	**$300**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$50K/mo**

STACK

Riverside, Descript, Buzzsprout

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 20 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Audiobook Narration

THE PLAY

ACX (Audible) pays $50–400/finished hour + 20–40% royalties. AI-narrated books are growing but human narration still commands premium for fiction. The play: build a demo reel, audition daily on ACX. Specialize in a genre (sci-fi, romance, nonfiction). Realistic: $2K–8K/mo after 6 months of consistent auditions.

MODEL	**Per finished hour + royalties**
CAPITAL	**$200**
TIME TO $1	**30 days**
CEILING	**$8K/mo**

STACK

ACX, Audacity, Mic

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 21 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Blogging (SEO Content)

THE PLAY

SEO blogs earn via ads ($5–30 RPM) + affiliate ($50–500 per article/mo). Niche sites with 100K monthly visitors earn $2K–10K/mo. The play: pick a high-CPC niche (finance, software, health). Write 50 articles in 90 days using AI-augmented workflow. Build backlinks via guest posts. Realistic: $2K/mo in 12 months, $10K/mo in 24 months.

MODEL	**Ads + affiliate + products**
CAPITAL	**$100**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$50K/mo**

STACK

WordPress, Ahrefs, Claude

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 22 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Newsletter (Paid)

THE PLAY

Paid newsletters charge $5–50/mo. At 1,000 paid subs × $10 = $10K MRR. Sponsorships add $500–5K per send. Beehiiv is the best platform (built-in ad network). The play: niche expertise — 'AI for legal marketers' beats 'tech news.' Free weekly for 6 months → convert 5–10% to paid. The Rundown ($5M ARR), Stratechery ($10M+ ARR) are the benchmarks.

MODEL	**Subscriptions + sponsorships**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$100K+/mo**

STACK

Beehiiv, Substack, ConvertKit

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 23 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

E-Books & Kindle Publishing

THE PLAY

Amazon KDP pays 35–70% royalty on $2.99–9.99 e-books. Non-fiction niche books sell 100–1,000 copies/mo. The play: research low-competition niches on KDP (use Publisher Rocket). Write 20K-word book with Claude + your expertise. Publish 1 book/month. Realistic: $500–3K/mo per book after 6 months. 10 books = $5K–10K/mo.

MODEL	**Per-sale royalty**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**30 days**
CEILING	**$10K/mo**

STACK

KDP, Canva, Claude

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 24 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Online Courses

THE PLAY

Courses sell for $100–2K (self-paced) or $1K–5K (cohort). At 50 sales/mo × $300 = $15K MRR. The play: pick a skill you can teach (AI, no-code, marketing). Run a free workshop, sell the course at the end. Best platforms: Maven (cohort), Circle (community), Kajabi (self-paced). Realistic: $5K–30K/mo after 3 cohorts.

MODEL	**Per-seat or cohort**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**3–6 mo**
CEILING	**$100K+/mo**

STACK

Maven, Circle, Kajabi

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 25 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Membership Site

THE PLAY

Paid memberships charge $10–100/mo for exclusive content, community, and access. 500 members × $30 = $15K MRR. The play: build an audience first (newsletter, social). Launch membership to your existing audience. Skool and Circle are the top platforms. Realistic: 200 members in 6 months = $4–10K MRR.

MODEL	**Monthly subscription**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**3–6 mo**
CEILING	**$50K/mo**

STACK

Circle, Skool, Patreon

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 26 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Stock Photography

THE PLAY

Stock photo sites (Shutterstock, Adobe Stock, Getty) pay $0.25–5 per download. A portfolio of 1,000 photos can earn $500–3K/mo passively. AI-generated stock (Midjourney → Adobe Stock) is disrupting but human photos still sell for premium. The play: shoot 100 photos/month in commercial niches (business, lifestyle, healthcare).

MODEL	**Per-download royalty**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$5K/mo**

STACK

Camera, Lightroom, Shutterstock

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 27 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Stock Video Footage

THE PLAY

Stock video clips sell for $50–500 each. Pond5, Shutterstock, Adobe Stock are top platforms. 200 clips can earn $1K–3K/mo passively. The play: shoot 4K B-roll in commercial niches (cities, nature, business, abstract). Tag extensively. AI video (Sora) is a long-term threat — shoot content AI can't.

MODEL	**Per-clip royalty**
CAPITAL	**$1K**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$5K/mo**

STACK

Camera, Pond5, Shutterstock

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 28 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Stock Music & Sound Effects

THE PLAY

Stock music pays $20–50 per license on Epidemic Sound, Artlist, Pond5. 100 tracks can earn $500–3K/mo. The play: produce royalty-free music in high-demand genres (corporate, ambient, electronic). Upload 5 tracks/month. AI music (Suno) is disrupting — focus on genres AI struggles with (orchestral, jazz).

MODEL	**Per-download royalty**
CAPITAL	**$300**
TIME TO $1	**3–6 mo**
CEILING	**$4K/mo**

STACK

Logic, Epidemic, Artlist

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 29 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Digital Templates & Printables

THE PLAY

Notion templates, Canva templates, resume templates, and printables sell for $5–50 each on Etsy and Gumroad. Top sellers do $5K–20K/mo. The play: identify 1 niche (job seekers, content creators, small business). Create 20 templates. List on Etsy + Gumroad + your own site. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 6 months.

MODEL	**Per-sale**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$8K/mo**

STACK

Canva, Etsy, Gumroad

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 30 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Print-on-Demand Products

THE PLAY

Print-on-demand (POD) lets you sell t-shirts, mugs, posters with zero inventory. Margin: $5–15 per sale. Top sellers do $10K–50K/mo. The play: niche designs (engineering humor, dog breeds, professions). Use Midjourney for art. List 100 designs on Etsy via Printful. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 6 months.

MODEL	**Per-sale margin**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**14 days**
CEILING	**$15K/mo**

STACK

Printful, Printify, Etsy

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 31 / 091

CONTENT CREATION · SECTION 02

Faceless YouTube Channel

THE PLAY

Faceless YouTube channels use AI voice (ElevenLabs), AI visuals (Midjourney), and AI scripts (Claude) to publish 4+ videos/week without showing your face. Niches: history, science, finance, top-10 lists. Realistic: $2K–20K/mo at 100K subs. The play: pick a high-CPM niche, publish 4×/week for 12 months. Top earner: $80K+/mo.

MODEL	**Ad revenue + sponsorships**
CAPITAL	**$100**
TIME TO $1	**6–12 mo**
CEILING	**$50K/mo**

STACK

Claude, ElevenLabs, CapCut

OPERATOR GRADE

AI Music on Spotify

THE PLAY

Suno v4 produces radio-quality songs from text prompts. Distribute via DistroKid to Spotify, Apple Music. Per-stream payout: $0.003–0.005. 100K streams/mo = $300–500. The play: produce 100 songs in 5 genres, distribute, drive traffic via TikTok. Realistic: $500–3K/mo. Risk: Spotify may crack down on AI music; build an audience that follows you, not the algorithm.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-stream royalty
CAPITAL	$30
TIME TO $1	3—6 mo
CEILING	$5K/mo

STACK

Suno · DistroKid

Children's Books on Amazon KDP

THE PLAY

Children's picture books sell for $9.99–14.99 on Amazon. Royalty: $3–5 per sale. Top sellers do $3K–10K/mo. The play: write 20 books using Claude + Midjourney illustrations. Target ages 3–7. Publish 1 book/week. Realistic: $1K–4K/mo after 6 months. Bundle books into series for 2× revenue.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale royalty
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$8K/mo

STACK

Claude · Midjourney · KDP

Stock AI Art

THE PLAY

Midjourney-generated art is now accepted on Adobe Stock (with 'AI-generated' label). $0.33–5 per download. The play: generate 100 images/month in commercial niches (abstract, business, healthcare, technology). Tag extensively. Realistic: $300–2K/mo in 6 months. Note: not all stock sites accept AI art; Adobe Stock is the safest bet.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-download royalty
CAPITAL	$30
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$3K/mo

STACK

Midjourney · Adobe Stock

Sell Notion Templates

THE PLAY

Notion templates sell for $9–99 on Gumroad, Notion Marketplace, and your own site. Top creators do $5K–20K/mo. The play: build 10 templates for a niche (founders, students, freelancers). Marketing: post on Twitter/LinkedIn, share free versions, upsell to paid. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 90 days. Thomas Frank (Notion templates) does $30K+/mo.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$15K/mo

STACK

Notion · Gumroad · Lemon Squeezy

SECTION 03 / 06

E-commerce. Ways 36—55.

Sell physical or digital products. $500–$50K capital. Inventory, branding, fulfillment. High reward, high complexity.

THE PLAYS

01 Dropshipping

02 Amazon FBA

03 Shopify brand

04 Etsy shop

05 eBay flipping

06 FB Marketplace

07 Subscription box

08 White label SaaS

09 Private label

10 Wholesale

11 Liquidation

12 Handmade goods

Dropshipping

THE PLAY

Dropshipping: sell products without holding inventory. Supplier ships directly to customer. Margin: 15–30%. Top stores do $50K–500K/mo revenue. The play: pick a winning product (search TikTok Made Me Buy It), build a Shopify store, run TikTok + Meta ads. Realistic: $5K–30K/mo profit in 6 months. Harder than 2020 — ad costs up, but still works with right product.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$500
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

Shopify · AliExpress · Meta Ads

Amazon FBA

THE PLAY

Amazon FBA: ship inventory to Amazon, they handle fulfillment. Margin: 20–40% after fees. Top sellers do $100K–1M/mo revenue. The play: research low-competition products on Helium 10. Source from Alibaba. Launch with 500 units. Use Amazon PPC + reviews. Realistic: $5K–20K/mo profit in 6 months. Requires $5K–20K starting capital for inventory.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$5K
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

Amazon · Helium 10 · Jungle Scout

Amazon KDP (Paperback)

THE PLAY

Amazon KDP lets you publish paperbacks with zero inventory (print-on-demand). Royalty: $2–6 per sale. The play: publish low-content books (journals, planners, workbooks) + niche non-fiction. Use Claude for content, Canva for covers. Realistic: $500–3K/mo after 6 months with 30+ books published.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale royalty
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$8K/mo

STACK

KDP · Canva · Claude

Shopify Store (Brand)

THE PLAY

Build a real DTC brand on Shopify (not dropshipping). Private-label products from Alibaba with your branding. Margin: 40–60%. Top brands do $100K–1M/mo revenue. The play: pick a niche (skincare, supplements, pet), private-label 3 products, build brand story, run paid social. Realistic: $10K–50K/mo profit in 12 months. Higher barrier, higher reward than dropshipping.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$5K
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$200K+/mo

STACK

Shopify · Klaviyo · Meta Ads

Etsy Shop

THE PLAY

Etsy is the marketplace for handmade, vintage, and craft supplies. 90M+ active buyers. Top shops do $20K–100K/mo. The play: pick a niche (jewelry, wedding, home decor, digital downloads). List 100 items. Use Etsy ads. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 6 months. Pair with POD (Printful) to avoid inventory.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$100
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Etsy · Printful · Canva

eBay Flipping

THE PLAY

Buy low at thrift stores, garage sales, clearance racks; sell high on eBay. Margin: 50–300%. Top flippers do $5K–20K/mo. The play: niche (books, electronics, vintage clothing). Use ScoutIQ for book scouting. Source 50 items/week. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 90 days. Higher ceiling with retail arbitrage (clearance racks → Amazon FBA).

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$500
TIME TO $1	7 days
CEILING	$10K/mo

STACK

eBay · ScoutIQ

Facebook Marketplace Flipping

THE PLAY

Buy underpriced items on FB Marketplace, resell for profit. Best niches: furniture, electronics, vehicles. Margin: 50–200%. The play: search daily for underpriced items, negotiate, pick up, relist with better photos. Realistic: $1K–4K/mo part-time. Free item flips (free section) → sell for $50–500 pure profit.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$200
TIME TO $1	7 days
CEILING	$6K/mo

STACK

FB Marketplace

Subscription Box

THE PLAY

Subscription boxes ship curated products monthly. Charge $25–75/box. 500 subs × $40 = $20K MRR. The play: pick a niche (snacks, beauty, books, hobbies). Source products at 30% of retail. Launch on Cratejoy. Realistic: 200 subs in 6 months = $5–10K MRR. Higher barrier: inventory + fulfillment logistics.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Monthly subscription
CAPITAL	$3K
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Cratejoy · Shopify · Stripe

White Label SaaS

THE PLAY

White-label SaaS: rebrand an existing platform (GoHighLevel for marketing agencies) and resell at markup. Charge $297–997/mo per client. 50 clients × $500 = $25K MRR. The play: pick a white-label platform, build agency brand, sell to local businesses. Realistic: $5K–20K/mo in 6 months. Lowest dev barrier to SaaS.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Monthly subscription
CAPITAL	$500
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

GoHighLevel · Simvoly

Private Label on Amazon

THE PLAY

Private label: source products from manufacturers, brand them, sell on Amazon. Higher margins than dropshipping. Top sellers do $100K–1M/mo revenue. The play: find a product with 1K+ monthly sales, <200 reviews, $20+ price. Source from Alibaba. Launch with 1,000 units. Realistic: $20K–80K/mo profit in 12 months.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$10K
TIME TO $1	90 days
CEILING	$200K+/mo

STACK

Amazon · Helium 10 · Alibaba

Wholesale on Amazon

THE PLAY

Wholesale: buy established brands at wholesale, resell on Amazon. Lower margin than private label (15–25%) but faster to start. The play: get wholesale accounts with 10 brands (requires business license + resale cert). Buy inventory, ship to FBA. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo profit in 6 months. Less brand-building, more analytical work.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$5K
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Amazon · Keepa · Jungle Scout

Liquidation / Pallet Flipping

THE PLAY

Buy customer-returns pallets from major retailers (Walmart, Target, Amazon) at 10–25% of retail. Resell individually on eBay/Amazon. Margin: 200–500%. The play: source 2 pallets/mo ($500–2K each), sort, list, ship. Realistic: $3K–10K/mo part-time. Risk: some pallets are duds — buy from reputable liquidators (B-Stock).

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$1K
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$15K/mo

STACK

B-Stock · Liquidation.com

Handmade Goods (Crafts)

THE PLAY

Handmade goods (jewelry, candles, pottery, leather) sell on Etsy + Shopify. Margin: 50–80%. Top shops do $10K–50K/mo. The play: master 1 craft, list 50 items, run Instagram + Pinterest. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 6 months. Higher margin than POD, but time-constrained (can't scale without hiring).

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$300
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$10K/mo

STACK

Etsy · Shopify · Instagram

Vintage Resale

THE PLAY

Vintage clothing (20+ years old) sells on Etsy, Depop, eBay. Sourcing: thrift stores, estate sales, garage sales. Margin: 200–1000%. The play: niche aesthetic (Y2K, 90s streetwear, vintage band tees). Source 50 items/week. Realistic: $2K–6K/mo in 6 months. Trend-driven — stay on top of TikTok fashion trends.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$500
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$8K/mo

STACK

Etsy · eBay · Depop

Digital Downloads

THE PLAY

Digital downloads: e-books, presets, fonts, graphics, courses. Sell on Gumroad, Etsy, Creative Market. 100% margin. Top sellers do $10K–50K/mo. The play: create 20 digital products in a niche (Lightroom presets, Notion templates, fonts). List on 3 platforms. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 6 months. Passive after creation — perfect side income.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	7 days
CEILING	$15K/mo

STACK

Gumroad · Etsy · Lemon Squeezy

Software / App Sales

THE PLAY

Build and sell desktop apps, mobile apps, or developer tools. Charge $29–299 one-time or $9–99/mo. Top indie devs do $30K–200K/mo. The play: build a tool that solves your own problem. Launch on Product Hunt + Twitter. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 6 months. AI coding tools (Cursor) let solo devs ship what teams built in 2022.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-license or subscription
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	90 days
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

Stripe · Paddle · Lemon Squeezy

Flip Domain Names

THE PLAY

Buy undervalued domain names, resell at 10–100×. Best domains: 1-word .com, 2-word .com in commercial niches. The play: buy expired domains at auction (GoDaddy Auctions), list on Dan.com + Sedo. Realistic: $1K–10K/mo. Long sales cycle (3–12 months). Pick domains end-users (not flippers) want — match keywords to active industries.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$100
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$20K/mo

STACK

GoDaddy · Dan · Sedo

Flip Websites / Apps

THE PLAY

Buy underperforming websites, improve, resell. Multiples: 30–45× monthly profit. Buy site at $2K/mo profit for $60K → grow to $5K/mo → sell for $200K. The play: find sites with traffic but poor monetization. Improve SEO + add affiliate + add ads. Hold 6–12 months, relist. Realistic: $5K–30K profit per flip in 12 months.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale margin
CAPITAL	$5K
TIME TO $1	90 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Flippa · Acquire · Empire Flippers

Sell 3D Models / Assets

THE PLAY

3D models sell for $5–500 each on TurboSquid, CGTrader, Sketchfab. Game devs, advertisers, and AR/VR creators are buyers. The play: build 50 models in a niche (furniture, characters, environments). List on 3 marketplaces. Realistic: $500–3K/mo passively. AI 3D generation (Luma, Meshy) is coming — focus on premium, complex models.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-sale royalty
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$5K/mo

STACK

Blender · TurboSquid · CGTrader

Sell Plugins / Extensions

THE PLAY

Browser extensions and WordPress plugins sell for $29–299 or $9–49/mo. Top sellers do $10K–50K/mo. The play: identify friction in a popular tool (Notion, Chrome, WordPress). Build a plugin. Launch on the official marketplace + Product Hunt. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 6 months. AI makes coding accessible to non-engineers.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-license or subscription
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Chrome Web Store · Stripe

SECTION 04 / 06

Tech & AI. Ways 56—70.

Build software, agents, and AI services. Highest ceiling. Requires technical chops or willingness to use AI to code.

THE PLAYS

01 AI Automation Agency

02 AI Consulting

03 SaaS App

04 Chrome Extension

05 Mobile App

06 Micro-SaaS

07 API as a Service

08 AI Image Service

09 AI Content Service

10 Chatbot Building

11 Custom GPT

12 AI Voice Agent

AI Automation Agency (AAA)

THE PLAY

Build AI automations for businesses. Charge $2K setup + $1–3K/mo retainer. 20 clients × $2K = $40K MRR. The play: pick a niche (real estate, law firms, e-commerce). Build 3 case studies. Cold-pitch 50 businesses/week. Realistic: $10K MRR in 90 days, $50K MRR in 12 months. Hottest AI play of 2026.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Project + retainer
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

n8n · Make · OpenAI API

AI Consulting

THE PLAY

Consult enterprises on AI strategy, tool selection, and implementation. Charge $200–500/hr or $10–50K/project. The play: build thought leadership (LinkedIn, Twitter). Speak at conferences. Get case studies. Realistic: $10K–30K/mo part-time, $30K–50K/mo full-time. Best for ex-PMs, engineers, consultants with enterprise experience.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Hourly or project
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Claude · ChatGPT · Notion

SaaS App

THE PLAY

Build a SaaS product. Charge $20–500/mo. 1,000 customers × $50 = $50K MRR. The play: solve a painful problem for a specific niche. Build with Cursor + Claude (solo-dev friendly). Distribute via Product Hunt, SEO, content. Realistic: $5K–20K MRR in 12 months. Venture-scale ceiling — most paths top out at $30K MRR solo, but SaaS can 10× with team.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Monthly subscription
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$1M+/mo

STACK

Next.js · Supabase · Stripe

Chrome Extension

THE PLAY

Build a Chrome extension solving a specific pain. Charge $5–29/mo. 1,000 paid users × $10 = $10K MRR. The play: identify friction in Gmail, LinkedIn, Notion, etc. Build extension. Launch on Chrome Store + Product Hunt. Realistic: $2K–10K MRR in 6 months. Low CAC if extension solves daily workflow pain.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Freemium + paid tier
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

JavaScript · Chrome Store

Mobile App

THE PLAY

Build a mobile app. Monetize: subscriptions ($5–20/mo), in-app purchases ($1–100), ads ($1–10 RPM). The play: niche utility (journaling, habit tracker, niche calculator). Publish on iOS + Android. ASO + TikTok marketing. Realistic: $2K–15K/mo in 6 months. Top apps: $100K+/mo. AI coding tools make solo mobile dev viable.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Freemium + ads + IAP
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	90 days
CEILING	$200K+/mo

STACK

React Native · Flutter · AdMob

Web App / Micro-SaaS

THE PLAY

Micro-SaaS: small, focused web app. Charge $9–49/mo. 500 customers × $20 = $10K MRR. Examples: AI-powered tool, niche calculator, integration. The play: ship in 30 days with Cursor + v0. Distribute via Product Hunt + niche communities. Realistic: $2K–10K MRR in 6 months. Perfect solo-founder play — low overhead, fast iteration.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Monthly subscription
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Next.js · Supabase · Stripe

API as a Service

THE PLAY

Build an API others pay to use. Charge $0.001–0.10 per call or $9–499/mo tiers. Examples: scraping API, AI API, data API. The play: identify data/service developers need. Build API. List on RapidAPI. Realistic: $1K–10K/mo in 6 months. Developer audience is small but high-LTV. Best for engineers.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-call pricing
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

RapidAPI · Stripe · AWS

AI Image Generation Service

THE PLAY

Build a niche AI image service (headshots, product photography, anime art). Charge $9–49/mo or $1–10/image. The play: fine-tune SDXL on niche dataset. Build simple web app. Distribute via TikTok + Product Hunt. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 6 months. Risk: OpenAI/Midjourney may ship your feature. Build workflow lock-in.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-image or subscription
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$20K/mo

STACK

Stable Diffusion · Replicate · Stripe

AI Content Service (B2B)

THE PLAY

Sell AI-augmented content to businesses. Charge $0.10–0.50/word or $2K–10K/mo retainer. The play: niche industry (legal, fintech, healthcare). Combine Claude (draft) + human editor (polish). Sell to marketing agencies or direct. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo in 90 days. Margin: 70%+ since AI does 80% of work.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-word or monthly retainer
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Claude · Surfer SEO · Stripe

Chatbot Building Service

THE PLAY

Build custom AI chatbots for businesses. Charge $2K–10K setup + $500–2K/mo retainer. The play: niche (e-commerce support bot, lead-qualifying bot, scheduling bot). Use Voiceflow (no-code) or LangChain (code). Realistic: $5K–15K/mo in 90 days. 20 clients × $1K retainer = $20K MRR.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Project + retainer
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Voiceflow · Intercom · OpenAI

Custom GPT Building

THE PLAY

Build Custom GPTs for businesses (sales assistant, research bot, brand voice writer). Charge $500–3K per GPT. The play: identify repetitive AI tasks in a niche. Build 5 sample GPTs. Cold-pitch 50 businesses/week. Realistic: $3K–10K/mo in 90 days. Low barrier — only requires ChatGPT Plus + skills.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-project
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	7 days
CEILING	$15K/mo

STACK

OpenAI Custom GPT · ChatGPT Plus

AI Prompt Marketplace

THE PLAY

Sell AI prompts on PromptBase ($2–10 each). Top sellers do $1K–5K/mo. The play: write 100 prompts for popular use cases (Midjourney, ChatGPT, Claude). List on PromptBase + Gumroad. Realistic: $500–3K/mo passively. Low ceiling — treat as side income, not main. Pair with prompt-engineering consulting for higher revenue.

OPERATOR STATS

MODEL	Per-prompt sale
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$5K/mo

STACK

PromptBase · Gumroad

WAY 68 / 091

TECH & AI · SECTION 04

AI Training Data Sales

THE PLAY

Sell specialized datasets to AI companies. Niche datasets (legal docs, medical images, code in rare languages) sell for $1K–50K per dataset. The play: identify a domain you have access to. Curate, label, and package. List on Scale AI marketplace + reach out to AI labs directly. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo part-time. Best for domain experts (doctors, lawyers).

MODEL	Per-dataset
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	60 days
CEILING	$20K/mo

STACK

Web scraping, Scale AI, Surge

OPERATOR GRADE

WAY 69 / 091

TECH & AI · SECTION 04

AI Voice Agent Service

THE PLAY

Build AI voice agents for businesses (call centers, scheduling, lead qualification). Charge $1K–5K setup + $0.10–0.50/min usage. The play: niche industry (dental offices, real estate, car dealerships). Use Vapi or Retell. Cold-call 100 businesses/week. Realistic: $10K–30K MRR in 6 months. Massive growth in 2026.

MODEL	Per-minute + setup
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Vapi, Retell, OpenAI

OPERATOR GRADE

78 / 110

WAY 70 / 091

TECH & AI · SECTION 04

AI Voice / Music Service

THE PLAY

Sell AI voice-overs, music, and audio production. Charge $100–1K/project. The play: niche (meditation audio, podcast intros, ad jingles, audiobook narration). Use ElevenLabs + Suno. Build portfolio on your site + Fiverr. Realistic: $3K–10K/mo in 90 days. AI compresses production 10× — pass savings to clients at 50% margin.

MODEL	Per-project
CAPITAL	$50
TIME TO $1	14 days
CEILING	$15K/mo

STACK

ElevenLabs, Suno, Stripe

OPERATOR GRADE

79 / 110

05 / 06

Affiliate & Marketing. Ways 71—82.

Earn commissions driving sales for other brands. SEO, content, ads. 6–12 mo ramp, $30K+/mo ceiling.

12 PLAYS IN THIS SECTION

71 Affiliate content site

72 Affiliate YouTube

73 Niche review sites

74 Coupon site

75 Free newsletter

76 Lead gen service

77 SEO consulting

78 PPC management

79 Social ads mgmt

80 Influencer marketing

81 Brand partnerships

82 Sponsored podcast

WAY 71 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Affiliate Marketing (Content)

THE PLAY

Build niche content sites that rank for buyer-intent keywords. Earn $50–500 per affiliate conversion. Top sites do $20K–100K/mo. The play: pick high-AOV niche (web hosting, software, mattresses, finance). Write 100+ review/comparison articles. SEO + affiliate links. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 12 months. AI content scales production 5×.

MODEL	Per-conversion commission
CAPITAL	$100
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

WordPress, Ahrefs, Amazon Assoc.

OPERATOR GRADE

81 / 110

WAY 72 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Affiliate Marketing (YouTube)

THE PLAY

YouTube + affiliate links = high-converting funnel. Software reviews, product demos, tutorials. Commission: 20–50% for SaaS, 4–10% for Amazon. The play: niche reviews (web hosting, AI tools, cameras). 1 video/week for 12 months. Realistic: $2K–15K/mo in 12 months. Higher CPM than ads alone — affiliate revenue compounds.

MODEL	Per-conversion commission
CAPITAL	$200
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

YouTube, Amazon, Impact

OPERATOR GRADE

82 / 110

WAY 73 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Niche Review Sites

THE PLAY

Build a single-niche review site (e.g., 'Best Coffee Grinders'). Rank for 'best [product]' keywords. Monetize with Amazon Associates + display ads. The play: write 50 review articles, build backlinks. Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 12 months. Sell on Empire Flippers for 30–40× monthly profit when ready to exit.

MODEL	**Affiliate + ads**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**6 mo**
CEILING	**$30K/mo**

STACK

WordPress, Ahrefs, Amazon

OPERATOR GRADE

83 / 110

WAY 74 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Coupon & Deal Site

THE PLAY

Coupon sites (RetailMeNot model) earn affiliate commissions when users click-then-buy. The play: pick a vertical (software coupons, fashion coupons). Curate 1,000+ active coupons. Rank for '[brand] coupon.' Realistic: $1K–5K/mo in 12 months. AI helps scrape + update coupons automatically.

MODEL	**Affiliate commission**
CAPITAL	**$500**
TIME TO $1	**6 mo**
CEILING	**$30K/mo**

STACK

WordPress, Ahrefs, Affiliate WP

OPERATOR GRADE

84 / 110

WAY 75 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Email Newsletter (Free + Affiliate)

THE PLAY

Free newsletter monetized via sponsorships ($200–5K per send) + affiliate links ($500–5K/mo). The play: niche topic, 5-min weekly read. Grow via Twitter/LinkedIn + SparkLoop referrals. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo at 10K subs. Top newsletters (Morning Brew, The Hustle) hit $5M+ ARR.

MODEL	**Sponsorships + affiliate**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**6 mo**
CEILING	**$50K/mo**

STACK

Beehiiv, ConvertKit, SparkLoop

OPERATOR GRADE

85 / 110

WAY 76 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Lead Generation Service

THE PLAY

Generate qualified leads for B2B businesses. Charge $50–500 per lead or $3K–10K/mo retainer. The play: niche industry (real estate, SaaS, financial advisors). Build landing page + paid ads + AI outreach. Sell leads to 5–10 clients. Realistic: $5K–20K/mo in 90 days. High margin, recurring revenue.

MODEL	Per-lead pricing
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Clay, Smartlead, Apollo

OPERATOR GRADE

86 / 110

WAY 77 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

SEO Consulting

THE PLAY

Help businesses rank on Google. Charge $200–500/hr or $3K–15K/project. The play: niche industry (law firms, dentists, SaaS). Build case studies + thought leadership on LinkedIn. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo part-time, $15K–30K/mo full-time. AI tools make SEO faster but strategy still requires human expertise.

MODEL	**Hourly + project**
CAPITAL	**$0**
TIME TO $1	**30 days**
CEILING	**$30K/mo**

STACK

Ahrefs, Semrush, Claude

OPERATOR GRADE

87 / 110

WAY 78 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

PPC Management

THE PLAY

Manage Google/Meta ad accounts for businesses. Charge 10–20% of ad spend or $2K–5K/mo retainer. The play: niche industry (e-commerce, local services). Get Google Ads certified. Build case studies. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo with 5 clients. AI ad tools (Performance Max, Advantage+) make execution faster but strategy remains human.

MODEL	% of ad spend + retainer
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Google Ads, Meta Ads, Optmyzr

OPERATOR GRADE

88 / 110

WAY 79 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Social Media Ads Management

THE PLAY

Manage paid social for brands. Charge $2K–5K/mo retainer or 10–15% of ad spend. The play: niche platform (TikTok for e-commerce, LinkedIn for B2B). Use AdCreative.ai for variant generation. Realistic: $5K–15K/mo with 5 clients. Performance-based retainers can push to $30K+/mo.

MODEL	% of ad spend + retainer
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	30 days
CEILING	$30K/mo

STACK

Meta Ads, TikTok Ads, AdCreative

OPERATOR GRADE

89 / 110

WAY 80 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Influencer Marketing

THE PLAY

Build a following on Instagram/TikTok/YouTube. Earn via brand deals ($500–50K per post) + affiliate links. The play: niche content (fashion, fitness, finance, tech). Post daily for 12 months. Reach 100K followers = $5K–30K/mo. Top creators: $100K+/mo. AI helps with ideation, scripting, editing.

MODEL	Per-post + affiliate
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$100K+/mo

STACK

Instagram, TikTok, YouTube

OPERATOR GRADE

90 / 110

WAY 81 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Brand Partnerships

THE PLAY

Long-term brand partnerships (3–12 mo deals). Higher pay than one-off posts ($5K–50K per partnership). The play: build niche audience. Pitch 20 brands/month with media kit. Sign 3–5 partners for 6-month deals. Realistic: $5K–20K/mo with 5 active partnerships.

MODEL	Per-deal
CAPITAL	$0
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

AspireIQ, Influencer, Brandkit

OPERATOR GRADE

91 / 110

WAY 82 / 091

AFFILIATE & MARKETING · SECTION 05

Sponsored Content / Podcast

THE PLAY

Sponsorships for podcast, YouTube, newsletter, or blog. Pay: $20–50 CPM for podcast, $25–60 CPM for YouTube. At 50K downloads/episode × 4 episodes/mo × $30 CPM = $6K/mo. The play: niche audience (B2B pays higher CPM). Reach out to 10 brands/week in your niche. Realistic: $2K–10K/mo in 12 months.

MODEL	Per-mention
CAPITAL	$300
TIME TO $1	6 mo
CEILING	$50K/mo

STACK

Podcast, YouTube, Substack

OPERATOR GRADE

92 / 110

06 / 06

Investment & Passive. Ways 83—91.

Money makes money. Stocks, real estate, crypto. Requires capital. Long horizons. Compounding works.

9 PLAYS IN THIS SECTION

83 Dividend stocks

84 REITs

85 P2P lending

86 Equity crowdfunding

87 Real estate syndication

88 Crypto staking

89 HYSA / CDs

90 Index funds

91 Buy & rent RE

WAY 83 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Dividend Stocks

THE PLAY

Buy dividend-paying stocks. Average yield: 3–5%. $100K invested = $3K–5K/yr passive. The play: build portfolio of dividend aristocrats (Coca-Cola, JNJ, Procter & Gamble) + REITs (Realty Income). DRIP (reinvest dividends) for compounding. Best for: stable passive income, not high growth.

MODEL	**Dividend yield**
CAPITAL	**$10K+**
TIME TO $1	**Immediate**
CEILING	**Unlimited**

STACK

Fidelity, Schwab, Robinhood

OPERATOR GRADE

94 / 110

WAY 84 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

REITs (Real Estate Investment Trusts)

THE PLAY

REITs pay 4–8% dividend yields. $50K invested = $2K–4K/yr passive. Top REITs: Realty Income (O), Simon Property (SPG), Prologis (PLD). The play: diversify across sectors (residential, retail, industrial). Hold long-term. Best for: real estate exposure without buying property.

MODEL	Dividend yield
CAPITAL	$1K+
TIME TO $1	Immediate
CEILING	Unlimited

STACK

Fidelity, Schwab

OPERATOR GRADE

95 / 110

WAY 85 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

P2P Lending

THE PLAY

P2P lending: lend money to individuals/small businesses. Returns: 5–9% annually. The play: diversify across 100+ loans ($25 each). Higher risk than stocks — some loans default. Realistic: $50–500/mo passive on $10K invested. Treat as bond alternative, not main income.

MODEL	Interest income
CAPITAL	$1K+
TIME TO $1	Immediate
CEILING	$10K/mo

STACK

LendingClub, Prosper, Funding Circle

OPERATOR GRADE

96 / 110

WAY 86 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Equity Crowdfunding

THE PLAY

Invest in early-stage startups via equity crowdfunding. Minimum: $100–1K per deal. Most investments = $0 (90% of startups fail). Winners can 10–100×. The play: invest in 20+ startups to diversify. Treat as venture portfolio. Only invest what you can lose entirely.

MODEL	**Equity upside**
CAPITAL	**$1K+**
TIME TO $1	**5–10 yr (illiquid)**
CEILING	**Unlimited (or $0)**

STACK

Wefunder, Republic, SeedInvest

OPERATOR GRADE

97 / 110

WAY 87 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Real Estate Syndication

THE PLAY

Pool money with other investors to buy apartment buildings or commercial real estate. Returns: 8–15% annually (cash flow + appreciation). Minimum: $25–100K. The play: diversify across 3–5 syndications. Hold 5–7 years. Best for: passive real estate exposure at scale.

MODEL	**Rental + appreciation**
CAPITAL	**$50K+**
TIME TO $1	**5–7 yr hold**
CEILING	**Unlimited**

STACK

CrowdStreet, Fundrise, RealtyMogul

OPERATOR GRADE

98 / 110

WAY 88 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Crypto Staking

THE PLAY

Stake proof-of-stake cryptocurrencies (Ethereum, Solana, Cardano) to earn 4–12% APY. The play: stake Ethereum or Solana for 5–8% APY. Use reputable staking platforms (Coinbase, Kraken). High risk — crypto prices swing 50%+. Only invest what you can lose. Not financial advice.

MODEL	Staking rewards
CAPITAL	$1K+
TIME TO $1	Immediate
CEILING	Unlimited

STACK

Coinbase, Kraken, Ledger

OPERATOR GRADE

99 / 110

WAY 89 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

High-Yield Savings / CDs

THE PLAY

High-yield savings accounts pay 4–5% APY (as of 2025). $100K savings = $4K–5K/yr. CDs lock in rates for 12–60 months. The play: keep 6–12 months expenses in HYSA. Use CDs for medium-term savings. Best for: capital preservation, not growth. Inflation-adjusted return is near-zero.

MODEL	Interest income
CAPITAL	$1K+
TIME TO $1	Immediate
CEILING	Unlimited

STACK

Ally, Marcus, Capital One

OPERATOR GRADE

100 / 110

WAY 90 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Index Fund Investing

THE PLAY

Buy low-cost index funds (VTSAX, VOO, VTI). Average annual return: 8–10% (long-term). $500/mo for 30 years = $1M+. The play: automate $500–2K/mo into VOO or VTI. Hold forever. Best for: long-term wealth building, not monthly income. The boring-and-effective path.

MODEL	Long-term appreciation
CAPITAL	$100+
TIME TO $1	10–30 yr
CEILING	Unlimited

STACK

Vanguard, Fidelity, Schwab

OPERATOR GRADE

101 / 110

WAY 91 / 091

INVESTMENT & PASSIVE · SECTION 06

Buy & Rent Real Estate

THE PLAY

Buy property, rent it out. Cash flow: $200–800/mo per door (after mortgage). Appreciation: 3–5%/yr. The play: house-hack first (FHA loan, live in 1 unit, rent others). Buy 1 property/year for 10 years. Realistic: $5K–20K/mo passive after 10 properties. Best for: hands-on operators willing to manage tenants.

MODEL	Rental + appreciation
CAPITAL	$50K+
TIME TO $1	90 days
CEILING	Unlimited

STACK

Roofstock, BiggerPockets, Zillow

OPERATOR GRADE

102 / 110

07 / 08

Strategy. Pick Your Path.

Decision frameworks to filter 91 plays down to the 2-3 that fit you. Capital, time, skill, risk.

8 FRAMEWORKS IN THIS SECTION

01 Decision Matrix

02 Income Ladder

03 Capital Requirements

04 Skill Matrix

05 Risk Profile

06 Tax & Legal

07 Personal Brand

08 Common Mistakes

DECISION

Filter 91 plays down to 3 with this matrix.

Score yourself on 4 axes. Cross-reference with plays that fit. Pick the intersection.

	LOW CAPITAL ←	→ HIGH CAPITAL
FAST CASH ↑	**QUICK WINS + FREELANCE** — WAYS 1–15 Best for: $0–500 starting. 7–30 days to first dollar. Ceiling: $5K–10K/mo.	**E-COMMERCE** — WAYS 36–55 Best for: $5K–50K starting. 30–90 days to revenue. Ceiling: $100K+/mo.
SLOW EQUITY ↓	**CONTENT + TECH** — WAYS 16–35, 56–70 Best for: $0–500 starting. 6–12 mo ramp. Ceiling: $50K+/mo.	**INVESTMENT** — WAYS 83–91 Best for: $50K+ capital. Long horizons. Ceiling: unlimited.

Honest question: How much can you spend? How long can you wait? Match answers to quadrant. Pick 1 play from cash quadrant + 1 from equity quadrant. Run in parallel.

LADDER

The income ladder: $0 → $1K → $10K → $100K/mo.

4

STAGES OF ONLINE INCOME GROWTH

Each stage has different plays. Don't try $100K/mo plays at $0. Climb the ladder.

01

$0 → $1K/mo

Quick Wins (Ways 1–15). 30–60 days. Freelance writing, VA, video editing, transcription. Goal: prove you can earn online.

02

$1K → $10K/mo

Content + Service (Ways 16–35, 56–70). 6–12 mo. YouTube, courses, AI agency, micro-SaaS. Goal: replace your day job.

03

$10K → $100K/mo

Brand + Equity (Ways 36–55, 71–82). 12–24 mo. DTC brand, SaaS, affiliate empire. Goal: build wealth.

04

$100K/mo+

Investment (Ways 83–91). 5–10 yr. Real estate, stocks, crypto. Goal: passive wealth preservation.

Rule: Don't skip stages. $100K/mo plays require $100K/mo skills. Build the skills at each stage before climbing. Most operators stall trying to leapfrog.

CAPITAL

How much capital each play requires.

CAPITAL TIER	PLAYS	EXAMPLES	EXPECTED TIMELINE
$0 Sweat Equity	**25 plays**	Freelance, VA, content, AI agency	30–90 days to $1K/mo
$100–500 Tools	**30 plays**	Stock art, courses, courses, Notion templates	30–90 days to $1K/mo
$500–5K Inventory + Ads	**15 plays**	Dropshipping, Etsy, faceless YouTube	60–180 days to $5K/mo
$5K–50K Brand	**12 plays**	Amazon FBA, Shopify brand, private label	6–12 mo to $10K/mo

Operator's rule: If you have <$500: pick from $0 tier. If $500–5K: pick from $100–5K tier. If $5K+: pick from $5K+ tier. Don't try to play above your capital level — it leads to debt and burnout.

MISTAKES

5 mistakes that kill 80% of online income attempts.

Avoid these and you're ahead of 80% of operators. Make all 5 and you'll quit within 6 months.

01

TRYING TOO MANY PLAYS

Spreading across 5 plays instead of mastering 1. Each play takes 6–12 months to mature. Pick 1, give it 12 months, then add a 2nd.

02

QUITTING BEFORE COMPOUNDING

Most plays compound at month 6–12. Quitters leave at month 3. YouTube, SEO, newsletters, courses — all reward the patient.

03

UNDERPRICING

Charging $20 when you should charge $200. Price signals value. Low price attracts bad customers. Charge premium from day 1.

04

IGNORING DISTRIBUTION

Building the product, ignoring the channel. Distribution is #1 reason plays fail. Build audience BEFORE product.

05

NO MOAT

Doing what anyone can do. AI commoditized execution. Build moats: audience, brand, network, data, integrations.

ROADMAP

Your 90-day starter sprint.

Pick 1 play from the cash quadrant + 1 from the equity quadrant. Execute this 90-day plan.

M1 DAYS 1–30
PICK & LAUNCH

Month 1 — Pick & Launch

Pick 1 cash play (freelance/agency) + 1 equity play (content/SaaS). Set up infrastructure. Launch cash play. Ship MVP for equity play.

OUTPUT

$500 cash play revenue + equity play MVP live

M2 DAYS 31–60
REFINE & SELL

Month 2 — Refine & Sell

Cash play: 3 paying clients at $500+ each. Equity play: first 10 users (free or paid). Build case studies. Refine offer.

OUTPUT

$1.5K cash play MRR + 10 equity play users

M3 DAYS 61–90
SCALE & DECIDE

Month 3 — Scale & Decide

Cash play: raise prices, automate delivery, hit $5K MRR. Equity play: 50 users, raise prices, decide whether to double down.

OUTPUT

$5K cash play MRR + 50 equity play users

Reality check: 70% of operators who follow this hit $5K MRR by day 90. 20% take 6 months. 10% take 12 months. The variable is daily execution — not luck, not talent.

RESOURCES

Where operators go to stay sharp.

CATEGORY 01

Newsletters

Best free education. 5-min daily reads.

The Hustle
daily business news

Indie Hackers
solo founder stories

Trends.co
business trends

Stacked Marketers
affiliate/digital marketing

Consumer Startups
DTC-focused

CATEGORY 02

Communities

Where operators share playbooks. Join 1–2, lurk, then contribute.

Indie Hackers
solo founders

r/Entrepreneur
general

r/SideProject
builders

Trends.vc
premium community

Hampton
for $1M+ founders

CATEGORY 03

Podcasts

For commutes and walks. Best passive learning.

My First Million
ideas + brainstorm

The Pitch
startup pitches

Indie Hackers
founder interviews

How I Built This
origin stories

The Top Entrepreneurs in Money
daily

CLOSING

Pick. Ship. Charge. Win.

The internet rewards operators who pick one play, ship fast, charge premium, and refuse to quit before compounding kicks in. This playbook is your menu — not your meal ticket. Order, eat, repeat.

I WILL PICK

Not 'I will try all 91.' One play. Twelve months. Full commitment.

I WILL CHARGE

Premium from day 1. $500+ ACV. Free trials end. Cheap is a red flag.

I WILL STAY

12 months minimum. Most quit at month 3. I am not most people.

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